

A decorative border with intricate floral and scrollwork patterns in a dark green color, framing the central text.

BibInVs MN 47

Corinthians2

Bible Translation:
Interverse MSG/NIV - 47

God

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Interversed Message/NIV Bible

2 Corinthians

2 Corinthians 1

MSG

NIV

- 1 I, Paul, have been sent on a special mission by the Messiah, Jesus, planned by God himself. I write this to God's congregation in Corinth, and to believers all over Achaia province.
- 1 Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God, and Timothy our brother, To the church of God in Corinth, together with all the saints throughout Achaia:
- 2 May all the gifts and benefits that come from God our Father and the Master, Jesus Christ, be yours! Timothy, someone you know and trust, joins me in this greeting.
- 2 Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.
- 3 All praise to the God and Father of our Master, Jesus the Messiah! Father of all mercy! God of all healing counsel!
- 3 Praise be to the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of compassion and the God of all comfort,
- 4 He comes alongside us when we go through hard times, and before you know it, he brings us alongside someone else who is going through hard times so that we can be there for that person just as God was there for us.
- 4 who comforts us in all our troubles, so that we can comfort those in any trouble with the comfort we ourselves have received from God.
- 5 We have plenty of hard times that come from following the Messiah, but no more so than the good times of his healing comfort--we get a full measure of that, too.
- 5 For just as the sufferings of Christ flow over into our lives, so also through Christ our comfort overflows.
- 6 When we suffer for Jesus, it works out for your healing and salvation. If we are treated well, given a helping hand and encouraging word, that

also works to your benefit, spurring you on, face forward, unflinching. Your hard times are also our hard times.

- 6 If we are distressed, it is for your comfort and salvation; if we are comforted, it is for your comfort, which produces in you patient endurance of the same sufferings we suffer.
- 7 When we see that you're just as willing to endure the hard times as to enjoy the good times, we know you're going to make it, no doubt about it.
- 7 And our hope for you is firm, because we know that just as you share in our sufferings, so also you share in our comfort.
- 8 We don't want you in the dark, friends, about how hard it was when all this came down on us in Asia province. It was so bad we didn't think we were going to make it.
- 8 We do not want you to be uninformed, brothers, about the hardships we suffered in the province of Asia. We were under great pressure, far beyond our ability to endure, so that we despaired even of life.
- 9 We felt like we'd been sent to death row, that it was all over for us. As it turned out, it was the best thing that could have happened. Instead of trusting in our own strength or wits to get out of it, we were forced to trust God totally--not a bad idea since he's the God who raises the dead!
- 9 Indeed, in our hearts we felt the sentence of death. But this happened that we might not rely on ourselves but on God, who raises the dead.
- 10 And he did it, rescued us from certain doom. And he'll do it again, rescuing us as many times as we need rescuing.
- 10 He has delivered us from such a deadly peril, and he will deliver us. On him we have set our hope that he will continue to deliver us,
- 11 You and your prayers are part of the rescue operation--I don't want you in the dark about that either. I can see your faces even now, lifted in praise for God's deliverance of us, a rescue in which your prayers played such a crucial part.
- 11 as you help us by your prayers. Then many will give thanks on our behalf for the gracious favor granted us in answer to the prayers of many.
- 12 Now that the worst is over, we're pleased we can report that we've come out of this with conscience and faith intact, and can face the world--and even more importantly, face you with our heads held high. But it wasn't

by any fancy footwork on our part. It was God who kept us focused on him, uncompromised.

12 Now this is our boast: Our conscience testifies that we have conducted ourselves in the world, and especially in our relations with you, in the holiness and sincerity that are from God. We have done so not according to worldly wisdom but according to God's grace.

13 Don't try to read between the lines or look for hidden meanings in this letter. We're writing plain, unembellished truth, hoping that

13 For we do not write you anything you cannot read or understand. And I hope that,

14 you'll now see the whole picture as well as you've seen some of the details. We want you to be as proud of us as we are of you when we stand together before our Master Jesus.

14 as you have understood us in part, you will come to understand fully that you can boast of us just as we will boast of you in the day of the Lord Jesus.

15 Confident of your welcome, I had originally planned two great visits with you--

15 Because I was confident of this, I planned to visit you first so that you might benefit twice.

16 coming by on my way to Macedonia province, and then again on my return trip. Then we could have had a bon-voyage party as you sent me off to Judea. That was the plan.

16 I planned to visit you on my way to Macedonia and to come back to you from Macedonia, and then to have you send me on my way to Judea.

17 Are you now going to accuse me of being flip with my promises because it didn't work out? Do you think I talk out of both sides of my mouth--a glib yes one moment, a glib no the next?

17 When I planned this, did I do it lightly? Or do I make my plans in a worldly manner so that in the same breath I say, "Yes, yes" and "No, no"?

18 Well, you're wrong. I try to be as true to my word as God is to his. Our word to you wasn't a careless yes canceled by an indifferent no. How could it be?

18 But as surely as God is faithful, our message to you is not "Yes" and "No."

- 19 When Silas and Timothy and I proclaimed the Son of God among you, did you pick up on any yes-and-no, on-again, off-again waffling? Wasn't it a clean, strong Yes?
- 19 For the Son of God, Jesus Christ, who was preached among you by me and Silas and Timothy, was not "Yes" and "No," but in him it has always been "Yes."
- 20 Whatever God has promised gets stamped with the Yes of Jesus. In him, this is what we preach and pray, the great Amen, God's Yes and our Yes together, gloriously evident.
- 20 For no matter how many promises God has made, they are "Yes" in Christ. And so through him the "Amen" is spoken by us to the glory of God.
- 21 God affirms us, making us a sure thing in Christ, putting his Yes within us.
- 21 Now it is God who makes both us and you stand firm in Christ. He anointed us,
- 22 By his Spirit he has stamped us with his eternal pledge--a sure beginning of what he is destined to complete.
- 22 set his seal of ownership on us, and put his Spirit in our hearts as a deposit, guaranteeing what is to come.
- 23 Now, are you ready for the real reason I didn't visit you in Corinth? As God is my witness, the only reason I didn't come was to spare you pain. I was being considerate of you, not indifferent, not manipulative.
- 23 I call God as my witness that it was in order to spare you that I did not return to Corinth.
- 24 We're not in charge of how you live out the faith, looking over your shoulders, suspiciously critical. We're partners, working alongside you, joyfully expectant. I know that you stand by your own faith, not by ours.
- 24 Not that we lord it over your faith, but we work with you for your joy, because it is by faith you stand firm.

2 Corinthians 2

MSG

NIV

- 1 That's why I decided not to make another visit that could only be painful to both of us.
- 1 So I made up my mind that I would not make another painful visit to you.
- 2 If by merely showing up I would put you in an embarrassingly painful position, how would you then be free to cheer and refresh me?
- 2 For if I grieve you, who is left to make me glad but you whom I have grieved?
- 3 That was my reason for writing a letter instead of coming--so I wouldn't have to spend a miserable time disappointing the very friends I had looked forward to cheering me up. I was convinced at the time I wrote it that what was best for me was also best for you.
- 3 I wrote as I did so that when I came I should not be distressed by those who ought to make me rejoice. I had confidence in all of you, that you would all share my joy.
- 4 As it turned out, there was pain enough just in writing that letter, more tears than ink on the parchment. But I didn't write it to cause pain; I wrote it so you would know how much I care--oh, more than care--love you!
- 4 For I wrote you out of great distress and anguish of heart and with many tears, not to grieve you but to let you know the depth of my love for you.
- 5 Now, regarding the one who started all this--the person in question who caused all this pain--I want you to know that I am not the one injured in this as much as, with a few exceptions, all of you. So I don't want to come down too hard.
- 5 If anyone has caused grief, he has not so much grieved me as he has grieved all of you, to some extent--not to put it too severely.
- 6 What the majority of you agreed to as punishment is punishment enough.
- 6 The punishment inflicted on him by the majority is sufficient for him.
- 7 Now is the time to forgive this man and help him back on his feet. If all you do is pour on the guilt, you could very well drown him in it.
- 7 Now instead, you ought to forgive and comfort him, so that he will not be overwhelmed by excessive sorrow.
- 8 My counsel now is to pour on the love.
- 8 I urge you, therefore, to reaffirm your love for him.
- 9 The focus of my letter wasn't on punishing the offender but on getting you to take responsibility for the health of the church.

- 9 The reason I wrote you was to see if you would stand the test and be obedient in everything.
- 10 So if you forgive him, I forgive him. Don't think I'm carrying around a list of personal grudges. The fact is that I'm joining in with your forgiveness, as Christ is with us, guiding us.
- 10 If you forgive anyone, I also forgive him. And what I have forgiven--if there was anything to forgive--I have forgiven in the sight of Christ for your sake,
- 11 After all, we don't want to unwittingly give Satan an opening for yet more mischief--we're not oblivious to his sly ways!
- 11 in order that Satan might not outwit us. For we are not unaware of his schemes.
- 12 When I arrived in Troas to proclaim the Message of the Messiah, I found the place wide open: God had opened the door; all I had to do was walk through it.
- 12 Now when I went to Troas to preach the gospel of Christ and found that the Lord had opened a door for me,
- 13 But when I didn't find Titus waiting for me with news of your condition, I couldn't relax. Worried about you, I left and came on to Macedonia province looking for Titus and a reassuring word on you.
- 13 I still had no peace of mind, because I did not find my brother Titus there. So I said good-bye to them and went on to Macedonia.
- 14 And I got it, thank God! In the Messiah, in Christ, God leads us from place to place in one perpetual victory parade. Through us, he brings knowledge of Christ. Everywhere we go, people breathe in the exquisite fragrance.
- 14 But thanks be to God, who always leads us in triumphal procession in Christ and through us spreads everywhere the fragrance of the knowledge of him.
- 15 Because of Christ, we give off a sweet scent rising to God, which is recognized by those on the way of salvation--an aroma redolent with life.
- 15 For we are to God the aroma of Christ among those who are being saved and those who are perishing.
- 16 But those on the way to destruction treat us more like the stench from a rotting corpse. This is a terrific responsibility. Is anyone competent to take it on?

- 16 To the one we are the smell of death; to the other, the fragrance of life.
And who is equal to such a task?
- 17 No--but at least we don't take God's Word, water it down, and then take it to the streets to sell it cheap. We stand in Christ's presence when we speak; God looks us in the face. We get what we say straight from God and say it as honestly as we can.
- 17 Unlike so many, we do not peddle the word of God for profit. On the contrary, in Christ we speak before God with sincerity, like men sent from God.

2 Corinthians 3

MSG

NIV

- 1 Does it sound like we're patting ourselves on the back, insisting on our credentials, asserting our authority? Well, we're not. Neither do we need letters of endorsement, either to you or from you.
- 1 Are we beginning to commend ourselves again? Or do we need, like some people, letters of recommendation to you or from you?
- 2 You yourselves are all the endorsement we need. Your very lives are a letter that anyone can read by just looking at you.
- 2 You yourselves are our letter, written on our hearts, known and read by everybody.
- 3 Christ himself wrote it--not with ink, but with God's living Spirit; not chiseled into stone, but carved into human lives--and we publish it.
- 3 You show that you are a letter from Christ, the result of our ministry, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God, not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts.
- 4 We couldn't be more sure of ourselves in this--that you, written by Christ himself for God, are our letter of recommendation.
- 4 Such confidence as this is ours through Christ before God.
- 5 We wouldn't think of writing this kind of letter about ourselves. Only God can write such a letter.
- 5 Not that we are competent in ourselves to claim anything for ourselves, but our competence comes from God.

- 6 His letter authorizes us to help carry out this new plan of action. The plan wasn't written out with ink on paper, with pages and pages of legal footnotes, killing your spirit. It's written with Spirit on spirit, his life on our lives!
- 6 He has made us competent as ministers of a new covenant--not of the letter but of the Spirit; for the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life.
- 7 The Government of Death, its constitution chiseled on stone tablets, had a dazzling inaugural. Moses' face as he delivered the tablets was so bright that day (even though it would fade soon enough) that the people of Israel could no more look right at him than stare into the sun.
- 7 Now if the ministry that brought death, which was engraved in letters on stone, came with glory, so that the Israelites could not look steadily at the face of Moses because of its glory, fading though it was,
- 8 How much more dazzling, then, the Government of Living Spirit?
- 8 will not the ministry of the Spirit be even more glorious?
- 9 If the Government of Condemnation was impressive, how about this Government of Affirmation?
- 9 If the ministry that condemns men is glorious, how much more glorious is the ministry that brings righteousness!
- 10 Bright as that old government was, it would look downright dull alongside this new one.
- 10 For what was glorious has no glory now in comparison with the surpassing glory.
- 11 If that makeshift arrangement impressed us, how much more this brightly shining government installed for eternity?
- 11 And if what was fading away came with glory, how much greater is the glory of that which lasts!
- 12 With that kind of hope to excite us, nothing holds us back.
- 12 Therefore, since we have such a hope, we are very bold.
- 13 Unlike Moses, we have nothing to hide. Everything is out in the open with us. He wore a veil so the children of Israel wouldn't notice that the glory was fading away--
- 13 We are not like Moses, who would put a veil over his face to keep the Israelites from gazing at it while the radiance was fading away.
- 14 and they didn't notice. They didn't notice it then and they don't notice it now, don't notice that there's nothing left behind that veil.

- 14 But their minds were made dull, for to this day the same veil remains when the old covenant is read. It has not been removed, because only in Christ is it taken away.
- 15 Even today when the proclamations of that old, bankrupt government are read out, they can't see through it. Only Christ can get rid of the veil so they can see for themselves that there's nothing there.
- 15 Even to this day when Moses is read, a veil covers their hearts.
- 16 Whenever, though, they turn to face God as Moses did, God removes the veil and there they are--face to face!
- 16 But whenever anyone turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away.
- 17 They suddenly recognize that God is a living, personal presence, not a piece of chiseled stone. And when God is personally present, a living Spirit, that old, constricting legislation is recognized as obsolete. We're free of it!
- 17 Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom.
- 18 All of us! Nothing between us and God, our faces shining with the brightness of his face. And so we are transfigured much like the Messiah, our lives gradually becoming brighter and more beautiful as God enters our lives and we become like him.
- 18 And we, who with unveiled faces all reflect the Lord's glory, are being transformed into his likeness with ever-increasing glory, which comes from the Lord, who is the Spirit.

2 Corinthians 4

MSG

NIV

- 1 Since God has so generously let us in on what he is doing, we're not about to throw up our hands and walk off the job just because we run into occasional hard times.
- 1 Therefore, since through God's mercy we have this ministry, we do not lose heart.
- 2 We refuse to wear masks and play games. We don't maneuver and manipulate behind the scenes. And we don't twist God's Word to suit ourselves. Rather, we keep everything we do and say out in the open, the

whole truth on display, so that those who want to can see and judge for themselves in the presence of God.

- 2 Rather, we have renounced secret and shameful ways; we do not use deception, nor do we distort the word of God. On the contrary, by setting forth the truth plainly we commend ourselves to every man's conscience in the sight of God.
- 3 If our Message is obscure to anyone, it's not because we're holding back in any way. No, it's because these other people are looking or going the wrong way and refuse to give it serious attention.
- 3 And even if our gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are perishing.
- 4 All they have eyes for is the fashionable god of darkness. They think he can give them what they want, and that they won't have to bother believing a Truth they can't see. They're stone-blind to the dayspring brightness of the Message that shines with Christ, who gives us the best picture of God we'll ever get.
- 4 The god of this age has blinded the minds of unbelievers, so that they cannot see the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.
- 5 Remember, our Message is not about ourselves; we're proclaiming Jesus Christ, the Master. All we are is messengers, errand runners from Jesus for you.
- 5 For we do not preach ourselves, but Jesus Christ as Lord, and ourselves as your servants for Jesus' sake.
- 6 It started when God said, "Light up the darkness!" and our lives filled up with light as we saw and understood God in the face of Christ, all bright and beautiful.
- 6 For God, who said, "Let light shine out of darkness," made his light shine in our hearts to give us the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ.
- 7 If you only look at us, you might well miss the brightness. We carry this precious Message around in the unadorned clay pots of our ordinary lives. That's to prevent anyone from confusing God's incomparable power with us.
- 7 But we have this treasure in jars of clay to show that this all-surpassing power is from God and not from us.

8 As it is, there's not much chance of that. You know for yourselves that we're not much to look at. We've been surrounded and battered by troubles, but we're not demoralized; we're not sure what to do,

8 We are hard pressed on every side, but not crushed; perplexed, but not in despair;

9 but we know that God knows what to do; we've been spiritually terrorized, but God hasn't left our side; we've been thrown down, but we haven't broken.

9 persecuted, but not abandoned; struck down, but not destroyed.

10 What they did to Jesus, they do to us--trial and torture, mockery and murder; what Jesus did among them, he does in us--he lives!

10 We always carry around in our body the death of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our body.

11 Our lives are at constant risk for Jesus' sake, which makes Jesus' life all the more evident in us.

11 For we who are alive are always being given over to death for Jesus' sake, so that his life may be revealed in our mortal body.

12 While we're going through the worst, you're getting in on the best!

12 So then, death is at work in us, but life is at work in you.

13 We're not keeping this quiet, not on your life. Just like the psalmist who wrote, "I believed it, so I said it," we say what we believe.

13 It is written: "I believed; therefore I have spoken." With that same spirit of faith we also believe and therefore speak,

14 And what we believe is that the One who raised up the Master Jesus will just as certainly raise us up with you, alive.

14 because we know that the one who raised the Lord Jesus from the dead will also raise us with Jesus and present us with you in his presence.

15 Every detail works to your advantage and to God's glory: more and more grace, more and more people, more and more praise!

15 All this is for your benefit, so that the grace that is reaching more and more people may cause thanksgiving to overflow to the glory of God.

16 So we're not giving up. How could we! Even though on the outside it often looks like things are falling apart on us, on the inside, where God is making new life, not a day goes by without his unfolding grace.

16 Therefore we do not lose heart. Though outwardly we are wasting away, yet inwardly we are being renewed day by day.

- 17 These hard times are small potatoes compared to the coming good times, the lavish celebration prepared for us.
- 17 For our light and momentary troubles are achieving for us an eternal glory that far outweighs them all.
- 18 There's far more here than meets the eye. The things we see now are here today, gone tomorrow. But the things we can't see now will last forever.
- 18 So we fix our eyes not on what is seen, but on what is unseen. For what is seen is temporary, but what is unseen is eternal.

2 Corinthians 5

MSG

NIV

- 1 For instance, we know that when these bodies of ours are taken down like tents and folded away, they will be replaced by resurrection bodies in heaven--God-made, not handmade--
- 1 Now we know that if the earthly tent we live in is destroyed, we have a building from God, an eternal house in heaven, not built by human hands.
- 2 and we'll never have to relocate our "tents" again. Sometimes we can hardly wait to move--and so we cry out in frustration. Compared to what's coming, living conditions around here seem like a stopover in an unfurnished shack, and we're tired of it! We've been given a glimpse of the real thing, our true home, our resurrection bodies!
- 2 Meanwhile we groan, longing to be clothed with our heavenly dwelling,
- 3 (SEE 5:2)
- 3 because when we are clothed, we will not be found naked.
- 4 (SEE 5:2)
- 4 For while we are in this tent, we groan and are burdened, because we do not wish to be unclothed but to be clothed with our heavenly dwelling, so that what is mortal may be swallowed up by life.
- 5 The Spirit of God whets our appetite by giving us a taste of what's ahead. He puts a little of heaven in our hearts so that we'll never settle for less.
- 5 Now it is God who has made us for this very purpose and has given us the Spirit as a deposit, guaranteeing what is to come.

- 6 That's why we live with such good cheer. You won't see us drooping our heads or dragging our feet! Cramped conditions here don't get us down. They only remind us of the spacious living conditions ahead.
- 6 Therefore we are always confident and know that as long as we are at home in the body we are away from the Lord.
- 7 It's what we trust in but don't yet see that keeps us going.
- 7 We live by faith, not by sight.
- 8 Do you suppose a few ruts in the road or rocks in the path are going to stop us? When the time comes, we'll be plenty ready to exchange exile for homecoming.
- 8 We are confident, I say, and would prefer to be away from the body and at home with the Lord.
- 9 But neither exile nor homecoming is the main thing. Cheerfully pleasing God is the main thing, and that's what we aim to do, regardless of our conditions.
- 9 So we make it our goal to please him, whether we are at home in the body or away from it.
- 10 Sooner or later we'll all have to face God, regardless of our conditions. We will appear before Christ and take what's coming to us as a result of our actions, either good or bad.
- 10 For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, that each one may receive what is due him for the things done while in the body, whether good or bad.
- 11 That keeps us vigilant, you can be sure. It's no light thing to know that we'll all one day stand in that place of Judgment. That's why we work urgently with everyone we meet to get them ready to face God. God alone knows how well we do this, but I hope you realize how much and deeply we care.
- 11 Since, then, we know what it is to fear the Lord, we try to persuade men. What we are is plain to God, and I hope it is also plain to your conscience.
- 12 We're not saying this to make ourselves look good to you. We just thought it would make you feel good, proud even, that we're on your side and not just nice to your face as so many people are.
- 12 We are not trying to commend ourselves to you again, but are giving you an opportunity to take pride in us, so that you can answer those who

- take pride in what is seen rather than in what is in the heart.
- 13 If I acted crazy, I did it for God; if I acted overly serious, I did it for you.
- 13 If we are out of our mind, it is for the sake of God; if we are in our right mind, it is for you.
- 14 Christ's love has moved me to such extremes. His love has the first and last word in everything we do. Our firm decision is to work from this focused center: One man died for everyone. That puts everyone in the same boat.
- 14 For Christ's love compels us, because we are convinced that one died for all, and therefore all died.
- 15 He included everyone in his death so that everyone could also be included in his life, a resurrection life, a far better life than people ever lived on their own.
- 15 And he died for all, that those who live should no longer live for themselves but for him who died for them and was raised again.
- 16 Because of this decision we don't evaluate people by what they have or how they look. We looked at the Messiah that way once and got it all wrong, as you know. We certainly don't look at him that way anymore.
- 16 So from now on we regard no one from a worldly point of view. Though we once regarded Christ in this way, we do so no longer.
- 17 Now we look inside, and what we see is that anyone united with the Messiah gets a fresh start, is created new. The old life is gone; a new life burgeons! Look at it!
- 17 Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; the old has gone, the new has come!
- 18 All this comes from the God who settled the relationship between us and him, and then called us to settle our relationships with each other.
- 18 All this is from God, who reconciled us to himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation:
- 19 God put the world square with himself through the Messiah, giving the world a fresh start by offering forgiveness of sins. God has given us the task of telling everyone what he is doing.
- 19 that God was reconciling the world to himself in Christ, not counting men's sins against them. And he has committed to us the message of reconciliation.

- 20 We're Christ's representatives. God uses us to persuade men and women to drop their differences and enter into God's work of making things right between them. We're speaking for Christ himself now: Become friends with God; he's already a friend with you.
- 20 We are therefore Christ's ambassadors, as though God were making his appeal through us. We implore you on Christ's behalf: Be reconciled to God.
- 21 How? you say. In Christ. God put the wrong on him who never did anything wrong, so we could be put right with God.
- 21 God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.

2 Corinthians 6

MSG

NIV

- 1 Companions as we are in this work with you, we beg you, please don't squander one bit of this marvelous life God has given us.
- 1 As God's fellow workers we urge you not to receive God's grace in vain.
- 2 God reminds us, I heard your call in the nick of time; The day you needed me, I was there to help. Well, now is the right time to listen, the day to be helped.
- 2 For he says, "In the time of my favor I heard you, and in the day of salvation I helped you." I tell you, now is the time of God's favor, now is the day of salvation.
- 3 Don't put it off; don't frustrate God's work by showing up late, throwing a question mark over everything we're doing.
- 3 We put no stumbling block in anyone's path, so that our ministry will not be discredited.
- 4 Our work as God's servants gets validated--or not--in the details. People are watching us as we stay at our post, alertly, unswervingly . . . in hard times, tough times, bad times;
- 4 Rather, as servants of God we commend ourselves in every way: in great endurance; in troubles, hardships and distresses;
- 5 when we're beaten up, jailed, and mobbed; working hard, working late, working without eating;

5 in beatings, imprisonments and riots; in hard work, sleepless nights and hunger;
6 with pure heart, clear head, steady hand; in gentleness, holiness, and honest love;
6 in purity, understanding, patience and kindness; in the Holy Spirit and in sincere love;
7 when we're telling the truth, and when God's showing his power; when we're doing our best setting things right;
7 in truthful speech and in the power of God; with weapons of righteousness in the right hand and in the left;
8 when we're praised, and when we're blamed; slandered, and honored; true to our word, though distrusted;
8 through glory and dishonor, bad report and good report; genuine, yet regarded as impostors;
9 ignored by the world, but recognized by God; terrifically alive, though rumored to be dead; beaten within an inch of our lives, but refusing to die;
9 known, yet regarded as unknown; dying, and yet we live on; beaten, and yet not killed;
10 immersed in tears, yet always filled with deep joy; living on handouts, yet enriching many; having nothing, having it all.
10 sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; poor, yet making many rich; having nothing, and yet possessing everything.
11 Dear, dear Corinthians, I can't tell you how much I long for you to enter this wide-open, spacious life.
11 We have spoken freely to you, Corinthians, and opened wide our hearts to you.
12 We didn't fence you in. The smallness you feel comes from within you. Your lives aren't small, but you're living them in a small way.
12 We are not withholding our affection from you, but you are withholding yours from us.
13 I'm speaking as plainly as I can and with great affection. Open up your lives. Live openly and expansively!
13 As a fair exchange--I speak as to my children--open wide your hearts also.

- 14 Don't become partners with those who reject God. How can you make a partnership out of right and wrong? That's not partnership; that's war. Is light best friends with dark?
- 14 Do not be yoked together with unbelievers. For what do righteousness and wickedness have in common? Or what fellowship can light have with darkness?
- 15 Does Christ go strolling with the Devil? Do trust and mistrust hold hands?
- 15 What harmony is there between Christ and Belial? What does a believer have in common with an unbeliever?
- 16 Who would think of setting up pagan idols in God's holy Temple? But that is exactly what we are, each of us a temple in whom God lives. God himself put it this way: "I'll live in them, move into them; I'll be their God and they'll be my people."
- 16 What agreement is there between the temple of God and idols? For we are the temple of the living God. As God has said: "I will live with them and walk among them, and I will be their God, and they will be my people."
- 17 So leave the corruption and compromise; leave it for good," says God. "Don't link up with those who will pollute you. I want you all for myself."
- 17 Therefore come out from them and be separate, says the Lord. Touch no unclean thing, and I will receive you.
- 18 I'll be a Father to you; you'll be sons and daughters to me." The Word of the Master, God.
- 18 I will be a Father to you, and you will be my sons and daughters, says the Lord Almighty.

2 Corinthians 7

MSG

NIV

- 1 With promises like this to pull us on, dear friends, let's make a clean break with everything that defiles or distracts us, both within and without. Let's make our entire lives fit and holy temples for the worship of God.

- 1 Since we have these promises, dear friends, let us purify ourselves from everything that contaminates body and spirit, perfecting holiness out of reverence for God.
- 2 Trust us. We've never hurt a soul, never exploited or taken advantage of anyone.
- 2 Make room for us in your hearts. We have wronged no one, we have corrupted no one, we have exploited no one.
- 3 Don't think I'm finding fault with you. I told you earlier that I'm with you all the way, no matter what.
- 3 I do not say this to condemn you; I have said before that you have such a place in our hearts that we would live or die with you.
- 4 I have, in fact, the greatest confidence in you. If only you knew how proud I am of you! I am overwhelmed with joy despite all our troubles.
- 4 I have great confidence in you; I take great pride in you. I am greatly encouraged; in all our troubles my joy knows no bounds.
- 5 When we arrived in Macedonia province, we couldn't settle down. The fights in the church and the fears in our hearts kept us on pins and needles. We couldn't relax because we didn't know how it would turn out.
- 5 For when we came into Macedonia, this body of ours had no rest, but we were harassed at every turn--conflicts on the outside, fears within.
- 6 Then the God who lifts up the downcast lifted our heads and our hearts with the arrival of Titus.
- 6 But God, who comforts the downcast, comforted us by the coming of Titus,
- 7 We were glad just to see him, but the true reassurance came in what he told us about you: how much you cared, how much you grieved, how concerned you were for me. I went from worry to tranquility in no time!
- 7 and not only by his coming but also by the comfort you had given him. He told us about your longing for me, your deep sorrow, your ardent concern for me, so that my joy was greater than ever.
- 8 I know I distressed you greatly with my letter. Although I felt awful at the time, I don't feel at all bad now that I see how it turned out. The letter upset you, but only for a while.
- 8 Even if I caused you sorrow by my letter, I do not regret it. Though I did regret it--I see that my letter hurt you, but only for a little while--

- 9 Now I'm glad--not that you were upset, but that you were jarred into turning things around. You let the distress bring you to God, not drive you from him. The result was all gain, no loss.
- 9 yet now I am happy, not because you were made sorry, but because your sorrow led you to repentance. For you became sorrowful as God intended and so were not harmed in any way by us.
- 10 Distress that drives us to God does that. It turns us around. It gets us back in the way of salvation. We never regret that kind of pain. But those who let distress drive them away from God are full of regrets, end up on a deathbed of regrets.
- 10 Godly sorrow brings repentance that leads to salvation and leaves no regret, but worldly sorrow brings death.
- 11 And now, isn't it wonderful all the ways in which this distress has goaded you closer to God? You're more alive, more concerned, more sensitive, more reverent, more human, more passionate, more responsible. Looked at from any angle, you've come out of this with purity of heart.
- 11 See what this godly sorrow has produced in you: what earnestness, what eagerness to clear yourselves, what indignation, what alarm, what longing, what concern, what readiness to see justice done. At every point you have proved yourselves to be innocent in this matter.
- 12 And that is what I was hoping for in the first place when I wrote the letter. My primary concern was not for the one who did the wrong or even the one wronged, but for you--that you would realize and act upon the deep, deep ties between us before God.
- 12 So even though I wrote to you, it was not on account of the one who did the wrong or of the injured party, but rather that before God you could see for yourselves how devoted to us you are.
- 13 That's what happened--and we felt just great. And then, when we saw how Titus felt--his exuberance over your response--our joy doubled. It was wonderful to see how revived and refreshed he was by everything you did.
- 13 By all this we are encouraged. In addition to our own encouragement, we were especially delighted to see how happy Titus was, because his spirit has been refreshed by all of you.

- 14 If I went out on a limb in telling Titus how great I thought you were, you didn't cut off that limb. As it turned out, I hadn't exaggerated one bit. Titus saw for himself that everything I had said about you was true.
- 14 I had boasted to him about you, and you have not embarrassed me. But just as everything we said to you was true, so our boasting about you to Titus has proved to be true as well.
- 15 He can't quit talking about it, going over again and again the story of your prompt obedience, and the dignity and sensitivity of your hospitality. He was quite overwhelmed by it all!
- 15 And his affection for you is all the greater when he remembers that you were all obedient, receiving him with fear and trembling.
- 16 And I couldn't be more pleased--I'm so confident and proud of you.
- 16 I am glad I can have complete confidence in you.

2 Corinthians 8

MSG

NIV

- 1 Now, friends, I want to report on the surprising and generous ways in which God is working in the churches in Macedonia province.
- 1 And now, brothers, we want you to know about the grace that God has given the Macedonian churches.
- 2 Fierce troubles came down on the people of those churches, pushing them to the very limit. The trial exposed their true colors: They were incredibly happy, though desperately poor. The pressure triggered something totally unexpected: an outpouring of pure and generous gifts.
- 2 Out of the most severe trial, their overflowing joy and their extreme poverty welled up in rich generosity.
- 3 I was there and saw it for myself. They gave offerings of whatever they could--far more than they could afford!--
- 3 For I testify that they gave as much as they were able, and even beyond their ability. Entirely on their own,
- 4 pleading for the privilege of helping out in the relief of poor Christians.
- 4 they urgently pleaded with us for the privilege of sharing in this service to the saints.

- 5 This was totally spontaneous, entirely their own idea, and caught us completely off guard. What explains it was that they had first given themselves unreservedly to God and to us. The other giving simply flowed out of the purposes of God working in their lives.
- 5 And they did not do as we expected, but they gave themselves first to the Lord and then to us in keeping with God's will.
- 6 That's what prompted us to ask Titus to bring the relief offering to your attention, so that what was so well begun could be finished up.
- 6 So we urged Titus, since he had earlier made a beginning, to bring also to completion this act of grace on your part.
- 7 You do so well in so many things--you trust God, you're articulate, you're insightful, you're passionate, you love us--now, do your best in this, too.
- 7 But just as you excel in everything--in faith, in speech, in knowledge, in complete earnestness and in your love for us--see that you also excel in this grace of giving.
- 8 I'm not trying to order you around against your will. But by bringing in the Macedonians' enthusiasm as a stimulus to your love, I am hoping to bring the best out of you.
- 8 I am not commanding you, but I want to test the sincerity of your love by comparing it with the earnestness of others.
- 9 You are familiar with the generosity of our Master, Jesus Christ. Rich as he was, he gave it all away for us--in one stroke he became poor and we became rich.
- 9 For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sakes he became poor, so that you through his poverty might become rich.
- 10 So here's what I think: The best thing you can do right now is to finish what you started last year and not let those good intentions grow stale.
- 10 And here is my advice about what is best for you in this matter: Last year you were the first not only to give but also to have the desire to do so.
- 11 Your heart's been in the right place all along. You've got what it takes to finish it up, so go to it.
- 11 Now finish the work, so that your eager willingness to do it may be matched by your completion of it, according to your means.

- 12 Once the commitment is clear, you do what you can, not what you can't.
The heart regulates the hands.
- 12 For if the willingness is there, the gift is acceptable according to what one has, not according to what he does not have.
- 13 This isn't so others can take it easy while you sweat it out. No, you're shoulder to shoulder with them all the way,
- 13 Our desire is not that others might be relieved while you are hard pressed, but that there might be equality.
- 14 your surplus matching their deficit, their surplus matching your deficit.
In the end you come out even.
- 14 At the present time your plenty will supply what they need, so that in turn their plenty will supply what you need. Then there will be equality,
- 15 As it is written, Nothing left over to the one with the most, Nothing lacking to the one with the least.
- 15 as it is written: "He who gathered much did not have too much, and he who gathered little did not have too little."
- 16 I thank God for giving Titus the same devoted concern for you that I have.
- 16 I thank God, who put into the heart of Titus the same concern I have for you.
- 17 He was most considerate of how we felt, but his eagerness to go to you and help out with this relief offering is his own idea.
- 17 For Titus not only welcomed our appeal, but he is coming to you with much enthusiasm and on his own initiative.
- 18 We're sending a companion along with him, someone very popular in the churches for his preaching of the Message.
- 18 And we are sending along with him the brother who is praised by all the churches for his service to the gospel.
- 19 But there's far more to him than popularity. He's rock-solid trustworthy. The churches handpicked him to go with us as we travel about doing this work of sharing God's gifts to honor God as well as we can,
- 19 What is more, he was chosen by the churches to accompany us as we carry the offering, which we administer in order to honor the Lord himself and to show our eagerness to help.
- 20 taking every precaution against scandal. We don't want anyone suspecting us of taking one penny of this money for ourselves.

- 20 We want to avoid any criticism of the way we administer this liberal gift.
- 21 We're being as careful in our reputation with the public as in our reputation with God.
- 21 For we are taking pains to do what is right, not only in the eyes of the Lord but also in the eyes of men.
- 22 That's why we're sending another trusted friend along. He's proved his dependability many times over, and carries on as energetically as the day he started. He's heard much about you, and liked what he's heard--so much so that he can't wait to get there.
- 22 In addition, we are sending with them our brother who has often proved to us in many ways that he is zealous, and now even more so because of his great confidence in you.
- 23 I don't need to say anything further about Titus. We've been close associates in this work of serving you for a long time. The brothers who travel with him are delegates from churches, a real credit to Christ.
- 23 As for Titus, he is my partner and fellow worker among you; as for our brothers, they are representatives of the churches and an honor to Christ.
- 24 Show them what you're made of, the love I've been talking up in the churches. Let them see it for themselves!
- 24 Therefore show these men the proof of your love and the reason for our pride in you, so that the churches can see it.

2 Corinthians 9

MSG

NIV

- 1 If I wrote any more on this relief offering for the poor Christians, I'd be repeating myself.
- 1 There is no need for me to write to you about this service to the saints.
- 2 I know you're on board and ready to go. I've been bragging about you all through Macedonia province, telling them, "Achaia province has been ready to go on this since last year." Your enthusiasm by now has spread to most of them.
- 2 For I know your eagerness to help, and I have been boasting about it to the Macedonians, telling them that since last year you in Achaia were

- ready to give; and your enthusiasm has stirred most of them to action.
- 3 Now I'm sending the brothers to make sure you're ready, as I said you would be, so my bragging won't turn out to be just so much hot air.
- 3 But I am sending the brothers in order that our boasting about you in this matter should not prove hollow, but that you may be ready, as I said you would be.
- 4 If some Macedonians and I happened to drop in on you and found you weren't prepared, we'd all be pretty red-faced--you and us--for acting so sure of ourselves.
- 4 For if any Macedonians come with me and find you unprepared, we--not to say anything about you--would be ashamed of having been so confident.
- 5 So to make sure there will be no slipup, I've recruited these brothers as an advance team to get you and your promised offering all ready before I get there. I want you to have all the time you need to make this offering in your own way. I don't want anything forced or hurried at the last minute.
- 5 So I thought it necessary to urge the brothers to visit you in advance and finish the arrangements for the generous gift you had promised. Then it will be ready as a generous gift, not as one grudgingly given.
- 6 Remember: A stingy planter gets a stingy crop; a lavish planter gets a lavish crop.
- 6 Remember this: Whoever sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and whoever sows generously will also reap generously.
- 7 I want each of you to take plenty of time to think it over, and make up your own mind what you will give. That will protect you against sob stories and arm-twisting. God loves it when the giver delights in the giving.
- 7 Each man should give what he has decided in his heart to give, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver.
- 8 God can pour on the blessings in astonishing ways so that you're ready for anything and everything, more than just ready to do what needs to be done.
- 8 And God is able to make all grace abound to you, so that in all things at all times, having all that you need, you will abound in every good work.

- 9 As one psalmist puts it, He throws caution to the winds, giving to the needy in reckless abandon. His right-living, right-giving ways never run out, never wear out.
- 9 As it is written: "He has scattered abroad his gifts to the poor; his righteousness endures forever."
- 10 This most generous God who gives seed to the farmer that becomes bread for your meals is more than extravagant with you. He gives you something you can then give away, which grows into full-formed lives, robust in God,
- 10 Now he who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food will also supply and increase your store of seed and will enlarge the harvest of your righteousness.
- 11 wealthy in every way, so that you can be generous in every way, producing with us great praise to God.
- 11 You will be made rich in every way so that you can be generous on every occasion, and through us your generosity will result in thanksgiving to God.
- 12 Carrying out this social relief work involves far more than helping meet the bare needs of poor Christians. It also produces abundant and bountiful thanksgivings to God.
- 12 This service that you perform is not only supplying the needs of God's people but is also overflowing in many expressions of thanks to God.
- 13 This relief offering is a prod to live at your very best, showing your gratitude to God by being openly obedient to the plain meaning of the Message of Christ. You show your gratitude through your generous offerings to your needy brothers and sisters, and really toward everyone.
- 13 Because of the service by which you have proved yourselves, men will praise God for the obedience that accompanies your confession of the gospel of Christ, and for your generosity in sharing with them and with everyone else.
- 14 Meanwhile, moved by the extravagance of God in your lives, they'll respond by praying for you in passionate intercession for whatever you need.
- 14 And in their prayers for you their hearts will go out to you, because of the surpassing grace God has given you.
- 15 Thank God for this gift, his gift. No language can praise it enough!

15 Thanks be to God for his indescribable gift!

2 Corinthians 10

MSG

NIV

- 1 And now a personal but most urgent matter; I write in the gentle but firm spirit of Christ. I hear that I'm being painted as cringing and wishy-washy when I'm with you, but harsh and demanding when at a safe distance writing letters.
- 1 By the meekness and gentleness of Christ, I appeal to you--I, Paul, who am "timid" when face to face with you, but "bold" when away!
- 2 Please don't force me to take a hard line when I'm present with you. Don't think that I'll hesitate a single minute to stand up to those who say I'm an unprincipled opportunist. Then they'll have to eat their words.
- 2 I beg you that when I come I may not have to be as bold as I expect to be toward some people who think that we live by the standards of this world.
- 3 The world is unprincipled. It's dog-eat-dog out there! The world doesn't fight fair. But we don't live or fight our battles that way--never have and never will.
- 3 For though we live in the world, we do not wage war as the world does.
- 4 The tools of our trade aren't for marketing or manipulation, but they are for demolishing that entire massively corrupt culture.
- 4 The weapons we fight with are not the weapons of the world. On the contrary, they have divine power to demolish strongholds.
- 5 We use our powerful God-tools for smashing warped philosophies, tearing down barriers erected against the truth of God, fitting every loose thought and emotion and impulse into the structure of life shaped by Christ.
- 5 We demolish arguments and every pretension that sets itself up against the knowledge of God, and we take captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ.
- 6 Our tools are ready at hand for clearing the ground of every obstruction and building lives of obedience into maturity.

- 6 And we will be ready to punish every act of disobedience, once your obedience is complete.
- 7 You stare and stare at the obvious, but you can't see the forest for the trees. If you're looking for a clear example of someone on Christ's side, why do you so quickly cut me out? Believe me, I am quite sure of my standing with Christ.
- 7 You are looking only on the surface of things. If anyone is confident that he belongs to Christ, he should consider again that we belong to Christ just as much as he.
- 8 You may think I overstate the authority he gave me, but I'm not backing off. Every bit of my commitment is for the purpose of building you up, after all, not tearing you down.
- 8 For even if I boast somewhat freely about the authority the Lord gave us for building you up rather than pulling you down, I will not be ashamed of it.
- 9 And what's this talk about me bullying you with my letters?
- 9 I do not want to seem to be trying to frighten you with my letters.
- 10 "His letters are brawny and potent, but in person he's a weakling and mumbles when he talks."
- 10 For some say, "His letters are weighty and forceful, but in person he is unimpressive and his speaking amounts to nothing."
- 11 Such talk won't survive scrutiny. What we write when away, we do when present. We're the exact same people, absent or present, in letter or in person.
- 11 Such people should realize that what we are in our letters when we are absent, we will be in our actions when we are present.
- 12 We're not, understand, putting ourselves in a league with those who boast that they're our superiors. We wouldn't dare do that. But in all this comparing and grading and competing, they quite miss the point.
- 12 We do not dare to classify or compare ourselves with some who commend themselves. When they measure themselves by themselves and compare themselves with themselves, they are not wise.
- 13 We aren't making outrageous claims here. We're sticking to the limits of what God has set for us. But there can be no question that those limits reach to and include you.

- 13 We, however, will not boast beyond proper limits, but will confine our boasting to the field God has assigned to us, a field that reaches even to you.
- 14 We're not moving into someone else's "territory." We were already there with you, weren't we? We were the first ones to get there with the Message of Christ, right? So how can there be any question of overstepping our bounds by writing or visiting you?
- 14 We are not going too far in our boasting, as would be the case if we had not come to you, for we did get as far as you with the gospel of Christ.
- 15 We're not barging in on the rightful work of others, interfering with their ministries, demanding a place in the sun with them. What we're hoping for is that as your lives grow in faith, you'll play a part within our expanding work.
- 15 Neither do we go beyond our limits by boasting of work done by others. Our hope is that, as your faith continues to grow, our area of activity among you will greatly expand,
- 16 And we'll all still be within the limits God sets as we proclaim the Message in countries beyond Corinth. But we have no intention of moving in on what others have done and taking credit for it.
- 16 so that we can preach the gospel in the regions beyond you. For we do not want to boast about work already done in another man's territory.
- 17 "If you want to claim credit, claim it for God."
- 17 But, "Let him who boasts boast in the Lord."
- 18 What you say about yourself means nothing in God's work. It's what God says about you that makes the difference.
- 18 For it is not the one who commends himself who is approved, but the one whom the Lord commends.

2 Corinthians 11

MSG

NIV

- 1 Will you put up with a little foolish aside from me? Please, just for a moment.
- 1 I hope you will put up with a little of my foolishness; but you are already doing that.

- 2 The thing that has me so upset is that I care about you so much--this is the passion of God burning inside me! I promised your hand in marriage to Christ, presented you as a pure virgin to her husband.
- 2 I am jealous for you with a godly jealousy. I promised you to one husband, to Christ, so that I might present you as a pure virgin to him.
- 3 And now I'm afraid that exactly as the Snake seduced Eve with his smooth patter, you are being lured away from the simple purity of your love for Christ.
- 3 But I am afraid that just as Eve was deceived by the serpent's cunning, your minds may somehow be led astray from your sincere and pure devotion to Christ.
- 4 It seems that if someone shows up preaching quite another Jesus than we preached--different spirit, different message--you put up with him quite nicely.
- 4 For if someone comes to you and preaches a Jesus other than the Jesus we preached, or if you receive a different spirit from the one you received, or a different gospel from the one you accepted, you put up with it easily enough.
- 5 But if you put up with these big-shot "apostles," why can't you put up with simple me? I'm as good as they are.
- 5 But I do not think I am in the least inferior to those "super-apostles."
- 6 It's true that I don't have their voice, haven't mastered that smooth eloquence that impresses you so much. But when I do open my mouth, I at least know what I'm talking about. We haven't kept anything back. We let you in on everything.
- 6 I may not be a trained speaker, but I do have knowledge. We have made this perfectly clear to you in every way.
- 7 I wonder, did I make a bad mistake in proclaiming God's Message to you without asking for something in return, serving you free of charge so that you wouldn't be inconvenienced by me?
- 7 Was it a sin for me to lower myself in order to elevate you by preaching the gospel of God to you free of charge?
- 8 It turns out that the other churches paid my way so that you could have a free ride.
- 8 I robbed other churches by receiving support from them so as to serve you.

- 9 Not once during the time I lived among you did anyone have to lift a finger to help me out. My needs were always supplied by the Christians from Macedonia province. I was careful never to be a burden to you, and I never will be, you can count on it.
- 9 And when I was with you and needed something, I was not a burden to anyone, for the brothers who came from Macedonia supplied what I needed. I have kept myself from being a burden to you in any way, and will continue to do so.
- 10 With Christ as my witness, it's a point of honor with me, and I'm not going to keep it quiet just to protect you from what the neighbors will think.
- 10 As surely as the truth of Christ is in me, nobody in the regions of Achaia will stop this boasting of mine.
- 11 It's not that I don't love you; God knows I do.
- 11 Why? Because I do not love you? God knows I do!
- 12 I'm just trying to keep things open and honest between us. And I'm not changing my position on this. I'd die before taking your money. I'm giving nobody grounds for lumping me in with those money-grubbing "preachers," vaunting themselves as something special.
- 12 And I will keep on doing what I am doing in order to cut the ground from under those who want an opportunity to be considered equal with us in the things they boast about.
- 13 They're a sorry bunch--pseudo-apostles, lying preachers, crooked workers--posing as Christ's agents but sham to the core.
- 13 For such men are false apostles, deceitful workmen, masquerading as apostles of Christ.
- 14 And no wonder! Satan does it all the time, dressing up as a beautiful angel of light.
- 14 And no wonder, for Satan himself masquerades as an angel of light.
- 15 So it shouldn't surprise us when his servants masquerade as servants of God. But they're not getting by with anything. They'll pay for it in the end.
- 15 It is not surprising, then, if his servants masquerade as servants of righteousness. Their end will be what their actions deserve.
- 16 Let me come back to where I started--and don't hold it against me if I continue to sound a little foolish. Or if you'd rather, just accept that I am

- a fool and let me rant on a little.
- 16 I repeat: Let no one take me for a fool. But if you do, then receive me just as you would a fool, so that I may do a little boasting.
- 17 I didn't learn this kind of talk from Christ.
- 17 In this self-confident boasting I am not talking as the Lord would, but as a fool.
- 18 Oh, no, it's a bad habit I picked up from the three-ring preachers that are so popular these days.
- 18 Since many are boasting in the way the world does, I too will boast.
- 19 Since you sit there in the judgment seat observing all these shenanigans, you can afford to humor an occasional fool who happens along.
- 19 You gladly put up with fools since you are so wise!
- 20 You have such admirable tolerance for impostors who rob your freedom, rip you off, steal you blind, put you down--even slap your face!
- 20 In fact, you even put up with anyone who enslaves you or exploits you or takes advantage of you or pushes himself forward or slaps you in the face.
- 21 I shouldn't admit it to you, but our stomachs aren't strong enough to tolerate that kind of stuff. Since you admire the egomaniacs of the pulpit so much (remember, this is your old friend, the fool, talking), let me try my hand at it.
- 21 To my shame I admit that we were too weak for that! What anyone else dares to boast about--I am speaking as a fool--I also dare to boast about.
- 22 Do they brag of being Hebrews, Israelites, the pure race of Abraham? I'm their match.
- 22 Are they Hebrews? So am I. Are they Israelites? So am I. Are they Abraham's descendants? So am I.
- 23 Are they servants of Christ? I can go them one better. (I can't believe I'm saying these things. It's crazy to talk this way! But I started, and I'm going to finish.) I've worked much harder, been jailed more often, beaten up more times than I can count, and at death's door time after time.
- 23 Are they servants of Christ? (I am out of my mind to talk like this.) I am more. I have worked much harder, been in prison more frequently, been flogged more severely, and been exposed to death again and again.
- 24 I've been flogged five times with the Jews' thirty-nine lashes,
- 24 Five times I received from the Jews the forty lashes minus one.

- 25 beaten by Roman rods three times, pummeled with rocks once. I've been shipwrecked three times, and immersed in the open sea for a night and a day.
- 25 Three times I was beaten with rods, once I was stoned, three times I was shipwrecked, I spent a night and a day in the open sea,
- 26 In hard traveling year in and year out, I've had to ford rivers, fend off robbers, struggle with friends, struggle with foes. I've been at risk in the city, at risk in the country, endangered by desert sun and sea storm, and betrayed by those I thought were my brothers.
- 26 I have been constantly on the move. I have been in danger from rivers, in danger from bandits, in danger from my own countrymen, in danger from Gentiles; in danger in the city, in danger in the country, in danger at sea; and in danger from false brothers.
- 27 I've known drudgery and hard labor, many a long and lonely night without sleep, many a missed meal, blasted by the cold, naked to the weather.
- 27 I have labored and toiled and have often gone without sleep; I have known hunger and thirst and have often gone without food; I have been cold and naked.
- 28 And that's not the half of it, when you throw in the daily pressures and anxieties of all the churches.
- 28 Besides everything else, I face daily the pressure of my concern for all the churches.
- 29 When someone gets to the end of his rope, I feel the desperation in my bones. When someone is duped into sin, an angry fire burns in my gut.
- 29 Who is weak, and I do not feel weak? Who is led into sin, and I do not inwardly burn?
- 30 If I have to "brag" about myself, I'll brag about the humiliations that make me like Jesus.
- 30 If I must boast, I will boast of the things that show my weakness.
- 31 The eternal and blessed God and Father of our Master Jesus knows I'm not lying.
- 31 The God and Father of the Lord Jesus, who is to be praised forever, knows that I am not lying.
- 32 Remember the time I was in Damascus and the governor of King Aretas posted guards at the city gates to arrest me?

- 32 In Damascus the governor under King Aretas had the city of the Damascenes guarded in order to arrest me.
- 33 I crawled through a window in the wall, was let down in a basket, and had to run for my life.
- 33 But I was lowered in a basket from a window in the wall and slipped through his hands.

2 Corinthians 12

MSG

NIV

- 1 You've forced me to talk this way, and I do it against my better judgment. But now that we're at it, I may as well bring up the matter of visions and revelations that God gave me.
- 1 I must go on boasting. Although there is nothing to be gained, I will go on to visions and revelations from the Lord.
- 2 For instance, I know a man who, fourteen years ago, was seized by Christ and swept in ecstasy to the heights of heaven. I really don't know if this took place in the body or out of it; only God knows.
- 2 I know a man in Christ who fourteen years ago was caught up to the third heaven. Whether it was in the body or out of the body I do not know-- God knows.
- 3 I also know that this man was hijacked into paradise--again, whether in or out of the body, I don't know; God knows. There he heard the unspeakable spoken, but was forbidden to tell what he heard.
- 3 And I know that this man--whether in the body or apart from the body I do not know, but God knows--
- 4 (SEE 12:3)
- 4 was caught up to paradise. He heard inexpressible things, things that man is not permitted to tell.
- 5 This is the man I want to talk about. But about myself, I'm not saying another word apart from the humiliations.
- 5 I will boast about a man like that, but I will not boast about myself, except about my weaknesses.
- 6 If I had a mind to brag a little, I could probably do it without looking ridiculous, and I'd still be speaking plain truth all the way. But I'll spare

- you. I don't want anyone imagining me as anything other than the fool you'd encounter if you saw me on the street or heard me talk.
- 6 Even if I should choose to boast, I would not be a fool, because I would be speaking the truth. But I refrain, so no one will think more of me than is warranted by what I do or say.
- 7 Because of the extravagance of those revelations, and so I wouldn't get a big head, I was given the gift of a handicap to keep me in constant touch with my limitations. Satan's angel did his best to get me down; what he in fact did was push me to my knees. No danger then of walking around high and mighty!
- 7 To keep me from becoming conceited because of these surpassingly great revelations, there was given me a thorn in my flesh, a messenger of Satan, to torment me.
- 8 At first I didn't think of it as a gift, and begged God to remove it. Three times I did that,
- 8 Three times I pleaded with the Lord to take it away from me.
- 9 and then he told me, My grace is enough; it's all you need. My strength comes into its own in your weakness. Once I heard that, I was glad to let it happen. I quit focusing on the handicap and began appreciating the gift. It was a case of Christ's strength moving in on my weakness.
- 9 But he said to me, "My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness." Therefore I will boast all the more gladly about my weaknesses, so that Christ's power may rest on me.
- 10 Now I take limitations in stride, and with good cheer, these limitations that cut me down to size--abuse, accidents, opposition, bad breaks. I just let Christ take over! And so the weaker I get, the stronger I become.
- 10 That is why, for Christ's sake, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong.
- 11 Well, now I've done it! I've made a complete fool of myself by going on like this. But it's not all my fault; you put me up to it. You should have been doing this for me, sticking up for me and commending me instead of making me do it for myself. You know from personal experience that even if I'm a nobody, a nothing, I wasn't second-rate compared to those big-shot apostles you're so taken with.

- 11 I have made a fool of myself, but you drove me to it. I ought to have been commended by you, for I am not in the least inferior to the "super-apostles," even though I am nothing.
- 12 All the signs that mark a true apostle were in evidence while I was with you through both good times and bad: signs of portent, signs of wonder, signs of power.
- 12 The things that mark an apostle--signs, wonders and miracles--were done among you with great perseverance.
- 13 Did you get less of me or of God than any of the other churches? The only thing you got less of was less responsibility for my upkeep. Well, I'm sorry. Forgive me for depriving you.
- 13 How were you inferior to the other churches, except that I was never a burden to you? Forgive me this wrong!
- 14 Everything is in readiness now for this, my third visit to you. But don't worry about it; you won't have to put yourselves out. I'll be no more of a bother to you this time than on the other visits. I have no interest in what you have--only in you. Children shouldn't have to look out for their parents; parents look out for the children.
- 14 Now I am ready to visit you for the third time, and I will not be a burden to you, because what I want is not your possessions but you. After all, children should not have to save up for their parents, but parents for their children.
- 15 I'd be most happy to empty my pockets, even mortgage my life, for your good. So how does it happen that the more I love you, the less I'm loved?
- 15 So I will very gladly spend for you everything I have and expend myself as well. If I love you more, will you love me less?
- 16 And why is it that I keep coming across these whiffs of gossip about how my self-support was a front behind which I worked an elaborate scam? Where's the evidence?
- 16 Be that as it may, I have not been a burden to you. Yet, crafty fellow that I am, I caught you by trickery!
- 17 Did I cheat or trick you through anyone I sent?
- 17 Did I exploit you through any of the men I sent you?
- 18 I asked Titus to visit, and sent some brothers along. Did they swindle you out of anything? And haven't we always been just as aboveboard, just as honest?

- 18 I urged Titus to go to you and I sent our brother with him. Titus did not exploit you, did he? Did we not act in the same spirit and follow the same course?
- 19 I hope you don't think that all along we've been making our defense before you, the jury. You're not the jury; God is the jury--God revealed in Christ--and we make our case before him. And we've gone to all the trouble of supporting ourselves so that we won't be in the way or get in the way of your growing up.
- 19 Have you been thinking all along that we have been defending ourselves to you? We have been speaking in the sight of God as those in Christ; and everything we do, dear friends, is for your strengthening.
- 20 I do admit that I have fears that when I come you'll disappoint me and I'll disappoint you, and in frustration with each other everything will fall to pieces--quarrels, jealousy, flaring tempers, taking sides, angry words, vicious rumors, swelled heads, and general bedlam.
- 20 For I am afraid that when I come I may not find you as I want you to be, and you may not find me as you want me to be. I fear that there may be quarreling, jealousy, outbursts of anger, factions, slander, gossip, arrogance and disorder.
- 21 I don't look forward to a second humiliation by God among you, compounded by hot tears over that crowd that keeps sinning over and over in the same old ways, who refuse to turn away from the pigsty of evil, sexual disorder, and indecency in which they wallow.
- 21 I am afraid that when I come again my God will humble me before you, and I will be grieved over many who have sinned earlier and have not repented of the impurity, sexual sin and debauchery in which they have indulged.

2 Corinthians 13

MSG

NIV

- 1 Well, this is my third visit coming up. Remember the Scripture that says, "A matter becomes clear after two or three witnesses give evidence"?
- 1 This will be my third visit to you. "Every matter must be established by the testimony of two or three witnesses."

- 2 On my second visit I warned that bunch that keeps sinning over and over in the same old ways that when I came back I wouldn't go easy on them. Now, preparing for the third, I'm saying it again from a distance. If you haven't changed your ways by the time I get there, look out.
- 2 I already gave you a warning when I was with you the second time. I now repeat it while absent: On my return I will not spare those who sinned earlier or any of the others,
- 3 You who have been demanding proof that Christ speaks through me will get more than you bargained for. You'll get the full force of Christ, don't think you won't.
- 3 since you are demanding proof that Christ is speaking through me. He is not weak in dealing with you, but is powerful among you.
- 4 He was sheer weakness and humiliation when he was killed on the Cross, but oh, he's alive now--in the mighty power of God! We weren't much to look at, either, when we were humiliated among you, but when we deal with you this next time, we'll be alive in Christ, strengthened by God.
- 4 For to be sure, he was crucified in weakness, yet he lives by God's power. Likewise, we are weak in him, yet by God's power we will live with him to serve you.
- 5 Test yourselves to make sure you are solid in the faith. Don't drift along taking everything for granted. Give yourselves regular checkups. You need firsthand evidence, not mere hearsay, that Jesus Christ is in you. Test it out. If you fail the test, do something about it.
- 5 Examine yourselves to see whether you are in the faith; test yourselves. Do you not realize that Christ Jesus is in you-- unless, of course, you fail the test?
- 6 I hope the test won't show that we have failed.
- 6 And I trust that you will discover that we have not failed the test.
- 7 But if it comes to that, we'd rather the test showed our failure than yours.
- 7 Now we pray to God that you will not do anything wrong. Not that people will see that we have stood the test but that you will do what is right even though we may seem to have failed.
- 8 We're rooting for the truth to win out in you.
- 8 For we cannot do anything against the truth, but only for the truth.
- 9 We couldn't possibly do otherwise. We don't just put up with our limitations; we celebrate them, and then go on to celebrate every

strength, every triumph of the truth in you. We pray hard that it will all come together in your lives.

9 We are glad whenever we are weak but you are strong; and our prayer is for your perfection.

10 I'm writing this to you now so that when I come I won't have to say another word on the subject. The authority the Master gave me is for putting people together, not taking them apart. I want to get on with it, and not have to spend time on reprimands.

10 This is why I write these things when I am absent, that when I come I may not have to be harsh in my use of authority--the authority the Lord gave me for building you up, not for tearing you down.

11 And that's about it, friends. Be cheerful. Keep things in good repair. Keep your spirits up. Think in harmony. Be agreeable. Do all that, and the God of love and peace will be with you for sure.

11 Finally, brothers, good-bye. Aim for perfection, listen to my appeal, be of one mind, live in peace. And the God of love and peace will be with you.

12 Greet one another with a holy embrace.

12 Greet one another with a holy kiss.

13 All the brothers and sisters here say hello.

13 All the saints send their greetings.

14 The amazing grace of the Master, Jesus Christ, the extravagant love of God, the intimate friendship of the Holy Spirit, be with all of you.

14 May the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all.